

XXXVII. The State Park Movement: 1864–1933

The story of American state parks begins with the 1864 cession of the Yosemite Valley and the Mariposa Big Tree Grove, then part of the public domain, to the State of California—unless one prefers to cite anew the remarkable Great Ponds Act of 1641 in the Massachusetts Bay colony. To avoid misunderstanding at the outset: the term *state park* will be used here in its usual generic sense, to include sizable county parks and the larger reservations of metropolitan park systems. All are on occasion referred to as “regional parks,” a term that eliminates any question about which level of government has control. Either term is workable; at any rate, the areas, differing considerably in size, ownership, and purpose, are all by custom regarded as products of the “state park movement.”

It would perhaps be an exaggeration to say that the *movement* began at Yosemite in 1864, since nothing comparable on a state level happened for another twenty years. But there can be little question that the action on Yosemite was doubly important, not only because it created the first state park in America, but also because of the long-range value of Olmsted's contribution to it (Fig. 343). Whereas Congress withdrew the land from the public domain and granted it to California “for public use, resort and recreation” in June 1864, the state legislature took until 1866 to accept the grant formally. Governor Low meanwhile wisely posted the tract against trespass and appointed an eight-man Yosemite Commission to work out policies for handling the area as a state property. Olmsted was a member of this group, and for it he prepared the preliminary report of 1865, now generally recog-



343. Yosemite Valley: the first state park, 1864.

nized as one of the most significant historic documents of what became the state park movement.¹

So far as is known today, Olmsted's report, written seven years before establishment of the Yellowstone, presented the first carefully reasoned statement to support the setting aside of great scenic areas for public ownership and enjoyment—a notion that was by no means the outcome of any tumultuous popular demand. In judging the report, one should bear in mind that here, as in the earlier case of Central Park, Olmsted was at heart a social reformer, deeply concerned for the welfare of “the mass of the people.” Having spent a month camping with his family in Yosemite during the summer of 1864, he was overwhelmed by its majesty and by the potential

1. Most of the report disappeared for many years; it was brought to light and published with an introductory note by Laura Wood Roper, Olmsted's biographer, in *Landscape Architecture*, 42 (October 1952). The quotations are from that article, pp. 12–25.

of such magnificent scenery for uplifting the health and spirit of those whose need was greatest.

It therefore results that the enjoyment of scenery employs the mind without fatigue and yet exercises it; tranquillizes it and yet enlivens it; and thus, through the influence of the mind over the body, gives the effect of refreshing rest and reinvigoration to the whole system.

Men who are rich enough . . . can and do provide places of this needed recreation for themselves. They have done so from the earliest periods known in the history of the world, for the great men . . . had their rural retreats . . . private parks and notable grounds devoted to luxury and recreation . . . The enjoyment of the choicest natural scenes in the country and the means of recreation connected with them is thus a monopoly, in a very peculiar manner, of a very few, very rich people. The great mass of society, including those to whom it would be of the greatest benefit, is excluded from it . . .

Thus without means are taken by government to withhold them from the grasp of individuals, all places favorable in scenery to the recreation of the mind and body will be closed against the great body of the people. For the same reason that the water of rivers should be guarded against private appropriation and . . . obstruction, portions of natural scenery may therefore properly be guarded and cared for by government. To simply reserve them from monopoly by individuals, however, it will be obvious, is not all that is necessary. It is necessary that they should be laid open to the use of the body of the people.

The establishment by government of great public grounds for the free enjoyment of the people under certain circumstances, is thus justified and enforced as a political duty.

The challenge presented by Central Park, largely a manmade landscape, had been quite different from the one before Olmsted in the existing wild landscape of the Yosemite. He saw clearly the kind of treatment needed here:

Congress enacted that the Yosemite should be held, guarded and managed for the free use of the whole body of the people forever, and that the care of it, and the hospitality of admitting strangers from all parts of the world to visit it and enjoy it freely, should be a duty of dignity and be committed only to a sovereign state.

The duty with which the Commissioners should be charged should be to give every advantage practicable to the mass of the people to benefit by that which is peculiar to this ground and which has caused Congress to treat it differently from other parts of the public domain. This peculiarity consists wholly in its natural scenery.

The first point to be kept in mind then is the preservation and maintenance as exactly as is possible of the natural scenery; the restriction,

that is to say, within the narrowest limits consistent with the necessary accommodation of visitors, of all artificial constructions and the prevention of all constructions markedly inharmonious with the scenery or which would unnecessarily obscure, distort or detract from the dignity of the scenery.

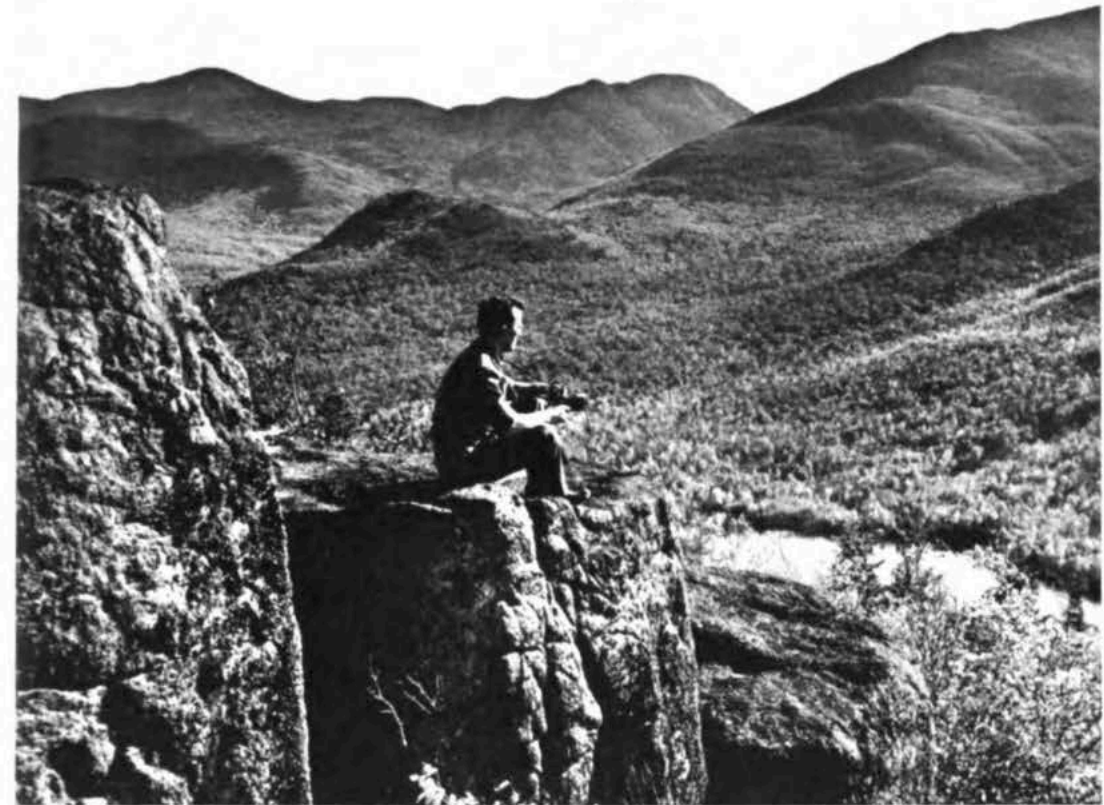
In an age when it was common custom on approaching a piece of land to attack it and wrest from it whatever material profit one could—timber, game, ore, crops—Olmsted's admonition regarding preservation and the rights of posterity must have sounded strange indeed:

It should, then, be made the duty of the Commission to prevent a wanton or careless disregard on the part of anyone entering the Yosemite or the Grove, of the rights of posterity as well as of contemporary visitors, and the Commission should be clothed with proper authority and given the necessary means for this purpose.

This duty of preservation is the first which falls upon the state under the Act of Congress, because the millions who are hereafter to benefit by the Act have the largest interest in it, and the largest interest should be first and most strenuously guarded."

Olmsted, yielding to Vaux's pleas to return east for the Brooklyn work, could not stay on in California long after presenting his Yosemite report; moreover, there is evidence to indicate that the report never reached the floor of the legislature. He certainly had laid the foundations for sound thinking about conservation, and he remained a dominant leader in park matters throughout his life; it is nevertheless clear that California profited less from Olmsted's insight and skill than might have been the case. At any rate, under the circumstances he could not be blamed for California's half-hearted management of the valley in ensuing years. To be sure, the state had the boundaries of the tract surveyed and did its best to remove the few early settlers. But the area was highly inaccessible, and maintaining it was far more costly than the legislature—or anyone else—had realized in those days of inexperience. The logical outcome was return of the state park lands to the United States in 1906.

Meanwhile, after Yosemite's establishment two decades had passed before there was action anywhere about state parks; in fact, development was spotty at best for over a half-century. Thus, although Olmsted, after his return from California (at least as early as 1869) conferred with other conservationists about the preservation of Niagara Falls, no conclusion was reached until 1885. In that year New York created the Niagara Falls Reservation, voting also one million dollars for purchase of land. Also in 1885, the New York legislature established with state-owned lands the huge Adirondack Forest Preserve, essentially a state park in purpose (Fig. 344). A few years later the smaller Catskill Preserve was marked out as a distinct unit. A "park" was later



344. In the Adirondack Forest Preserve of northern New York.

designated within the famous but puzzling "blue line," to include large portions of the Adirondack Preserve but also private holdings under rigorous protective restrictions by the state. Rounding out the three isolated instances of state park addition in 1885, the federally owned Mackinac Island, in the straits between Lake Michigan and Lake Huron, was transferred to the State of Michigan. It had been set aside in 1879, though rather tentatively, as a national military park because of the historically important Fort Michilimackinac of colonial days.

Spasmodic state park progress continued into the 1890s. A step of permanent significance was taken by Minnesota in 1891, when acquisition was begun on lands that became Lake Itasca State Park, containing the headwaters of the Mississippi River (Fig. 345). An earlier chapter contained Charles Eliot's success story in establishing, in 1891, the Trustees of Public Reservations in Massachusetts and then in 1892 the first metropolitan park system in the world. The system's two large forested areas, the Middlesex Fells and the Blue Hills Reservation, are normally classed as state parks in type, although their development for human enjoyment has been relatively slight.



345. Headwaters of the Mississippi River, in Minnesota's Itasca State Park.

The year 1895 was marked by three notable events: the birth of one of the most effective early conservation bodies, the American Scenic and Historic Preservation Society; the start of the first county park organization, in Essex County, New Jersey; the first private acquisition of portions of the Palisades of the Hudson, across from New York City and lower Westchester County, made possible by J. Pierpont Morgan, heading off the mining of this geological marvel for traprock. Five years later, in 1900, the Palisades Interstate

Park was established, to include a strip of land along the west side of the Hudson in New York and New Jersey. Management was ingeniously placed in the hands of two theoretically independent ten-man commissions, one from each state. But by friendly agreement the same ten members, five residents of each state, customarily made up the "two" commissions. This fine example of enlightened cooperation was not covered by legislation until 1937, when an interstate compact was passed by the two legislatures and approved by Congress.

During the first decade of the twentieth century New York State enjoyed the benefits of several separate actions cited here simply to illustrate how state park systems can slowly take shape through private donations accompanied by an appropriately intelligent and receptive public attitude. In 1906, under urging by the American Scenic and Historic Preservation Society, the state acquired Watkins Glen, a fantastic geologic phenomenon of rocky cliffs, cascades, and grottos at the southern end of Seneca Lake. Then in 1907 the legislature approved appointment of the Bronx River Parkway Commission to study and solve the problems presented by that stream on the Westchester approaches to New York City. Again in 1907, William P. Letchworth gave the state his tract of over a thousand acres in the western part of the state,

346. The gorge of the Genesee River in western New York, part of the Letchworth tract.

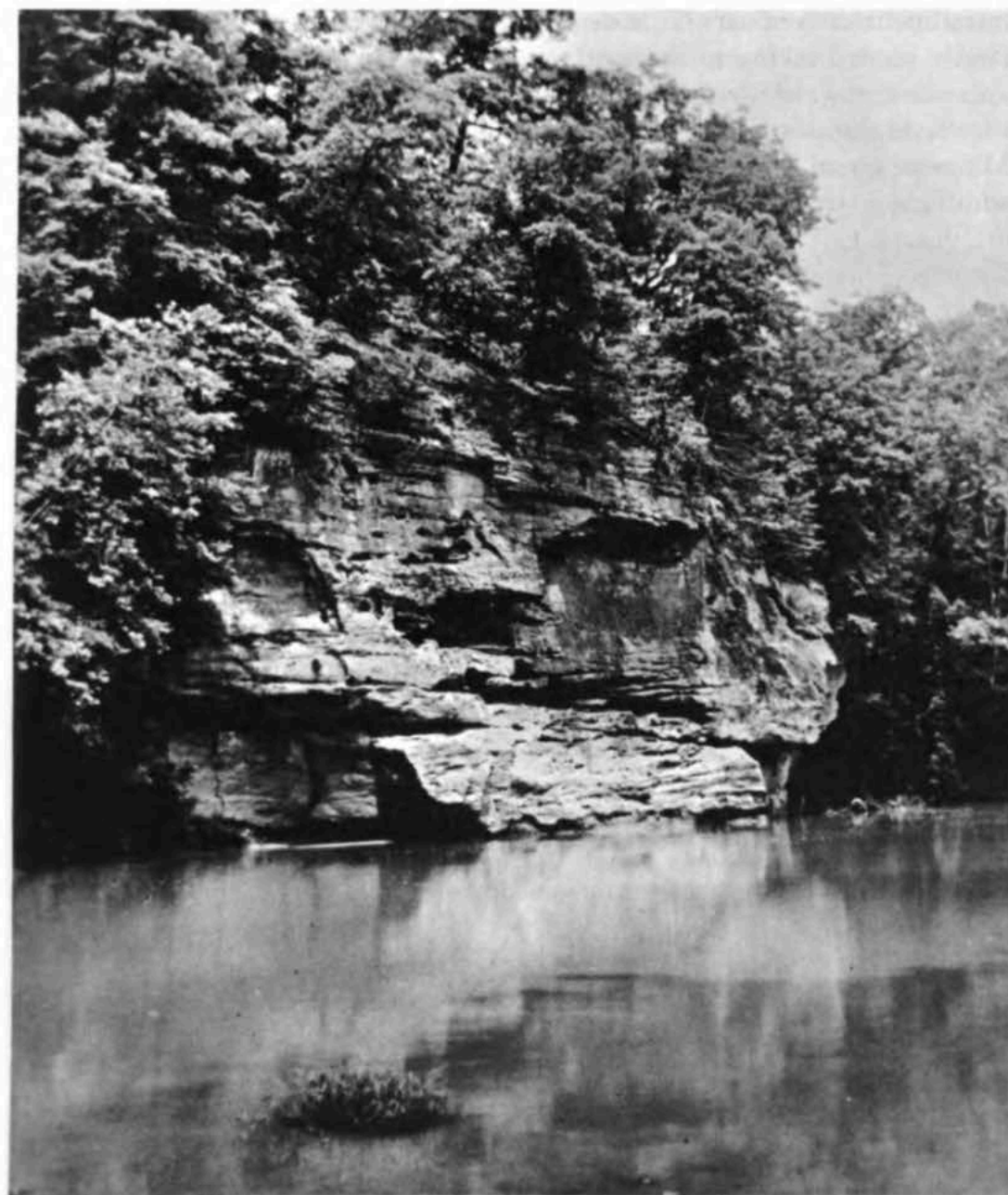


including Portage Falls and the awe-inspiring gorge of the Genesee River (Fig. 346). Topping even this, in 1910 the Harriman family gave the state over forty thousand acres of rough, forested land reaching to the southwest from Bear Mountain on the Hudson, for addition to the holdings of the Palisades Interstate Park Commission. Almost as though to voice appreciation of its great good luck, the people of the state voted in 1910 to approve a bond issue of \$2,500,000, an unprecedented act in both purpose and amount, for purchase of state park lands. Six years later another bond issue, this time for \$10,000,000, was approved by the voters. New York was thus well prepared for the momentous upward surge of state park activity right after World War I.

Although the state park movement as such was still sputtering, a modicum of progress was discernible in other states between 1900 and the end of the war. At the turn of the century, Minnesota and Wisconsin created separate interstate parks facing each other across the St. Croix River. At the same time in Massachusetts the Mount Greylock, Wachusett Mountain, and Mount Tom Reservations were set aside. In 1902 Ohio converted into state parks several thousand acres around reservoir lakes left over from an abandoned canal system. As early as 1911, Idaho brought in Payette Lake and Heyburn State Parks, and Illinois established Starved Rock State Park. Wisconsin, having formed a State Park Board in 1907, engaged landscape architect John Nolen to do a study of the state's park potentials, and then saved from destruction Devil's Lake and Nelson-Dewey State Parks; between 1910 and 1914 several thousand acres of forest in the Peninsula State Park were added. During the same years, Pennsylvania assembled the Valley Forge and Fort Washington State Parks, and in 1912 Connecticut set up its State Park Commission, which quickly began acquiring lands for several new parks.

In Illinois, the renowned Cook County Forest Preserve District was created by popular vote in 1914 as an encircling belt of recreational areas about Chicago. New Jersey with Swartswood Lake State Park and North Carolina with Mount Mitchell State Park joined the list in 1915. In 1916 Indiana, under the leadership of Colonel Richard Lieber, established its first units in McCormick's Creek Canyon and Turkey Run State Parks (Fig. 347), preliminary to setting up one of the strongest of the early state park organizations. In 1918, after many years of hard work, the ten thousand-acre California Redwood State Park came into being and the remarkable Save-the-Redwoods League was formed. Also in 1918, Iowa made a start with Backbone State Park and Connecticut added Macedonia Brook State Park.

The foregoing, given in some detail for the sake of fairness to the most progressive states, may seem quite an accomplishment. But in plain fact, at the end of World War I, more than a half-century after establishment of the Yosemite as the first of its kind, there was not a very heartening performance to look back at in terms of a state park movement. Fifty-five years had



347. Turkey Run State Park, Indiana.

produced little more than a handful of state parks, scattered among one-third of the states. Only New York, Indiana, Wisconsin, Connecticut, and possibly California had anything even approaching a firm state park organization, and none of these owned what could reasonably be called a *system* of state parks. Then, within a relatively brief period, things began to happen. At least two specific factors appear to have been catalytic. The impact of the automobile, which had been slowly but surely making the American people more mobile, was highly intensified at the end of the war by the promotion of

installment sales of cars. To a degree unknown in earlier years the American family started taking to the road, and the demand for outdoor recreational areas shot upward accordingly. In the two years immediately after the armistice several states, especially those wheelhorses Connecticut, Iowa, Michigan, Minnesota, and Wisconsin, responded with new parks. A number of notable additions were initiated in 1919 and 1920, such as Old Salem State Park in Illinois, Clifty Falls State Park in Indiana, Enfield Glen (later R. H. Treman) State Park in New York, and the huge Custer State Park in South Dakota, that state's first.

A second catalyst was Stephen Mather, who as director of the National Park Service had the sensible notion of looking to an ample, nationwide system of state parks to serve as a buffer to protect the great national parks from a dangerous avalanche of motorized visitors. After all, the most pressing public demand was for intensive recreation—for such day-use facilities as bathing beaches and picnic grounds, for short-term rather than long-term use. State parks could be geared for these purposes just as well as national parks and often better. Moreover, dense urban populations would normally find state parks nearer and more easily accessible than national parks. For intensive recreation, the superlative scenery of the national parks was certainly not a primary requirement; indeed, facilities for swimming would in many cases appear more important. Of a more modest scenic level than national parks, state parks of satisfying quality would be easier to find, justify, and establish. The move toward more state parks, Mather may have surmised, might also curtail the large number of low-grade, unqualified national park proposals than being urged upon the Park Service by ambitious politicians and local groups.

To Mather, having a thought meant acting on it; in this case it meant organizing one of the national conferences for which he was already famous. Beginning in 1920, he enlisted the interest and services of conservationists in many states. He called to a meeting in Chicago a small group of key reliables; they agreed with the proposal for a big conference and settled on Des Moines as a good central place. Mather immediately engaged, at his own expense, a young enthusiast whom he sent to Des Moines two months in advance to pave the way. Secretary of the Interior John Barton Payne, impressed by Mather's reasoning, had given the endeavor his blessing; the hearty cooperation of Iowa's Governor W. L. Harding was readily obtained.

At Mather's request the Governor sent out thousands of formal invitations to a general park conference, especially urging the governors of the other states to send delegations. When the forces gathered at Des Moines for what turned out to be an epochal meeting early in 1921, twenty-five states were represented by over two hundred individuals. This group quickly organized as the National Conference on State Parks, with Secretary Payne as its first chairman. The Des Moines meeting had profound results, not only in the founding of

the NCSP, which still holds annual meetings and is a source of strength, but also in such a resurgence of interest and determination that it could at last be fairly said that a state park movement was on the way. The years following the meeting showed the value of a shared concern and concerted efforts. Wholly new parks were added in twenty states, including eight that had

348. Buttermilk Falls State Park, a unit of the Finger Lakes State Park Commission.





349. Jones Beach State Park, Long Island, an outstanding example of state park planning and design: air view from the west.

owned no state parks before 1921. Despite the known slowness of democratic legislative processes, no less than seventeen states created their first state park boards or commissions between 1921 and 1927 or otherwise enacted laws clarifying the responsibility and authority for management of the state's recreational and scenic areas.

An example of such legislative remodeling was that of 1927 in New York. A State Council of Parks, organized in 1924 on studies reaching back to 1922, was placed under a new Division of Parks in the state's Department of Conservation. Replacing a patchwork situation under which various independent boards and societies had administered areas all over the state, the new legislation provided final cement for one of the nation's largest and strongest unified state park systems. This divided the state into regions, each

under the charge of an unpaid commission of private citizens appointed by the governor and each with a professional staff, including in most cases at least one landscape architect. The chairmen or presidents of the several regional commissions constituted the State Council, which was responsible for allocation of funds provided by the state's budget. When final adjustment of regional boundaries had been effected, the divisions were Niagara Frontier, Allegany, Genesee, Finger Lakes (Fig. 348), Central New York, Thousand Islands, Adirondack, Taconic, Palisades Interstate, and Long Island. Robert Moses, president of the Long Island State Park Commission, was elected chairman of the State Council when it organized in 1924.

The need for such consolidations was obvious in a state the size of New York, with so many parks of wide diversity in location, topography, vegetative cover, and manner of use. According to a report of the NCSP, New York had by 1928 fifty-six units, with over two million acres of land. These parks included large tracts of near-wilderness, to be sure, but they also illustrated the increasing trend toward intensive recreation that had caused Mather to reach his conclusions about the national role of state parks. Outstanding in the category of areas for intensive use is Jones Beach State Park (Fig. 349), installed on the south shore of Long Island in the summer of 1929. A superb work of landscape design, this great park extends along several miles of wide ocean beach, dispersing with astonishing evenness a use-population of unbelievable thousands. Toward one end is the East Bathhouse (Fig. 350); toward the other, with an enclosed fresh-water pool, is the West Bathhouse. Midway between them is the Central Mall (Fig. 351), with its widely recognized water tower and the main arrival circle of the Wantagh Parkway. There are snack and dining facilities at all three points. The entire length of the

350. The East Bathhouse at Jones Beach State Park.





351. The Central Mall and water tower at Jones Beach State Park.

park is tied together in simple, straightforward geometry, chiefly by means of a wide, raised boardwalk that fronts on the beach from one bathhouse to the other, with carefully delimited game areas along its north side throughout. A long, straight road runs the length of the park on the landward side of the bathhouses, with arrival turns at each of these and at the Central Mall. North of the road there are enormous parking areas for thousands of cars, with pedestrian underpasses leading to bathhouses and beach. Drinking

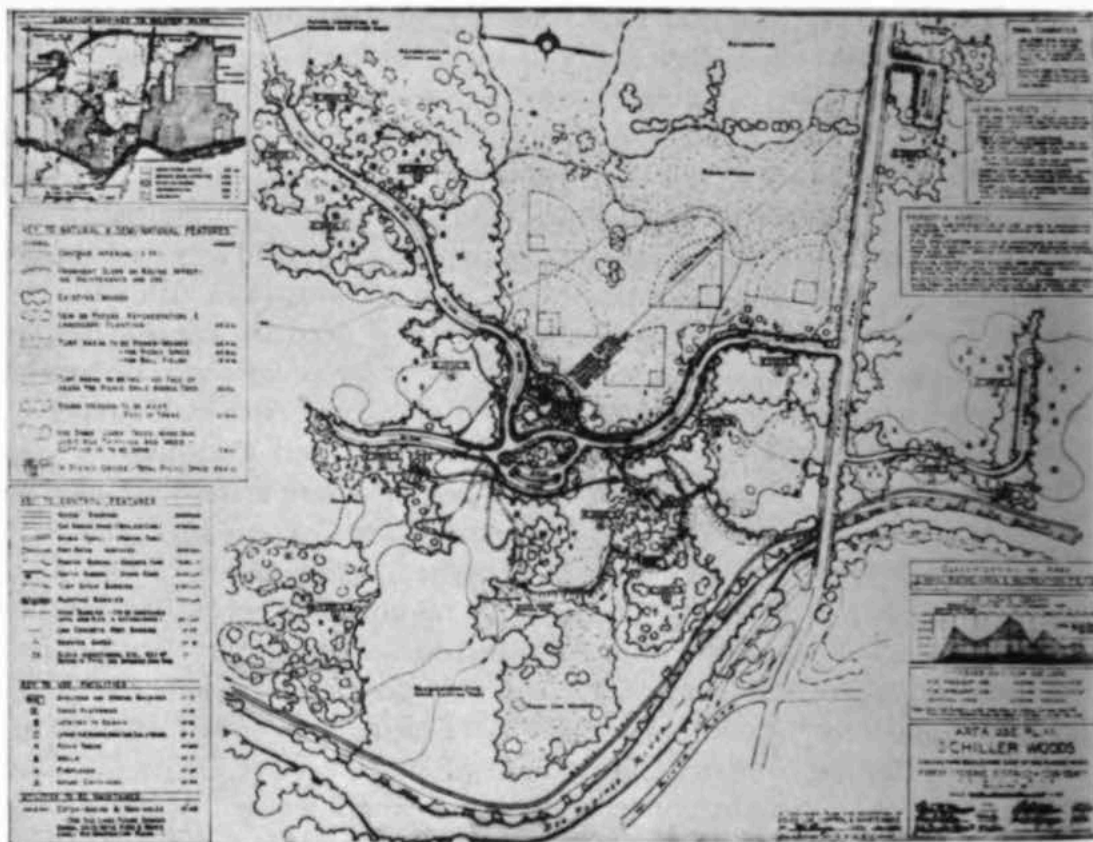
fountains, benches, inconspicuous trash receptacles, and occasional sunshelters are distributed at logical points in the geometry of the plan.

One of the most remarkable aspects of Jones Beach is the way the site accepts it. All the land outside the clearly bounded use-areas has been allowed to remain in its native ocean-front condition. The dunes, firmly anchored by beach grass, bayberry, beach plum, and jack pine, have flourished unharmed for forty years. The heartening fact is that these wild areas are simply not invaded by the public. Indeed, the whole place illustrates brilliantly the power of design to affect human behavior and, if need be, control it. One looks in vain for litter; uncouth activity is virtually unknown. The overall landscape design is a masterpiece; it was done in large part by Clarence C. Combs, landscape architect of the Long Island State Park Commission, with help from, among others, Melvin B. Borgeson, a landscape architect on emergency loan from the Westchester County Park Commission.

New York was thus providing by 1929 a type of state park devoted almost wholly to intensive recreational use by large numbers of people. The Empire State was no doubt more advanced in this direction than other states, but the recreational trend was moving along in many of the twenty-five states with state parks by the end of the 1920s. One of the most noteworthy of this kind of park system was the Cook County Forest Preserve District around Chicago, a belt of partially connected holdings totaling over thirty thousand acres. Though not state property, but an autonomous entity within Cook County, these parks have customarily been regarded as of the state park type and are usually so classified. In the words of a Commissioner, the Cook County Forest Preserve District is "a forested sanctuary with recreational facilities for appropriate forms of intensive use on the fringes."² This brief statement merits attention, especially in view of the tremendous amount of recreation actually provided by the District through the years.

In 1929 Charles G. Sauers, the landscape architect who had been Colonel Lieber's right-hand man in Indiana, became general superintendent of the Cook County Forest Preserve District. The District's landscape architect was John Barstow Morrill. Under their guidance and that of their professional colleagues at the headquarters in River Forest, the system demonstrated how well a set of parks can accommodate intensive recreation. Surely no sterner test could be imposed than the pressure of such nearby metropolitan masses of eager users. Yet, basic policy of the District required that its areas must remain essentially pieces of near-wild nature. No situation could more insistently have demanded continual invention of appropriate new techniques of design and management to keep the parks in service without thereby destroying them through wear and tear. And this is precisely what Sauers and Morrill accomplished. Their job was of incalculable value, not only for

2. Forest Preserve District of Cook County, Illinois, *Annual Report*, 1957, p. 5.



352. Cook County Forest Preserve District of Illinois: the layout of Schiller Woods picnic groves, illustrating the value of careful planning for mass use of wooded areas.

its own practical purposes, but also because it showed how a design problem tends to solve itself if permitted to do so on its own terms of site and function, without the designer's imposing a preconception of form.

Among other departures from standard practice, Sauers and Morrill devised simple new ways of employing durable building materials, particularly straightforward types of concrete structures that did not pretend to be something else, yet looked comfortably at home in the forest about them. The two experimented with—and applied with marked success—a policy of alternate areas for group picnicking, so that a “grove” could be chained off and rested through a season or more, enabling it to restore itself naturally to usable condition while its mate was being used (Figs. 352, 353).

The Forest Preserve District was an all-year operation, with winter sports an integral part of the program, notably in the Palos Hills ski area with its multiple toboggan slides. In summer the major activity was of course at the swimming pools, with thousands of picnic permits running a close second. The parks of the District, in short, were used throughout the year by the people of Cook County in enormous numbers, but the basic “forested sanctuary” character was not lost. The reason for this was primarily a careful adherence



353. Air view of Schiller Woods, looking north (from right in the plan); alternating use of picnic groves aids in maintaining healthy vegetation year after year.

to the fundamental caution already quoted: “facilities for *appropriate forms* of intensive use on the fringes.”

The question of what constitutes an “appropriate form” of recreation arises often in discussions of state park policies. There appears to be general agreement against providing a facility that requires too large an area of carefully graded and treated surface, such as baseball diamonds, tennis courts, running tracks, or athletic fields; not only because in form such areas would be incongruous in the normally rough or undulant terrain of a state park, but also because psychologically they would introduce an equally incongruous urban atmosphere. The following language from an annual report of the Cook County District suggests a somewhat differently stated reason for the fine success of its many programs: “The District offers no organized recreation . . . we believe organized recreation belongs in the truly municipal park system.”³

While in the east and the midwest 1929 brought such intensive recreational developments as Jones Beach and the parks of the Cook County Preserve,

3. *Ibid.*, 1940, p. 174.

other events of great import were taking place on the west coast. In California, Olmsted's famous state park report, one of his most widely cited writings, was published in 1929. Events there had begun in 1927, with the enactment in Sacramento of legislation establishing a state park commission, authorizing a popular referendum on a bond issue of six million dollars for purchase of state parks, and providing for a survey of the state's park potentials. California had at the time five state park areas, but these had been assembled rather fortuitously, without any overall plan, and were administered by different appointive bodies. Perhaps the strongest single organization was the private Save-the-Redwoods League. Pursuant to the 1927 legislation, Governor Young appointed five distinguished Californians to the new centralized commission. They in turn, to implement the provision for a study of the state's potentials, engaged Olmsted. How appropriate it was that this report should be made by the man whose father wrote the first state park report in California! To assist him, Olmsted took on a small staff: Daniel R. Hull of Los Angeles, former chief landscape architect of the National Park Service, Harry W. Shepherd, of the University of California at Berkeley, and Emerson Knight, of San Francisco. All were members of the ASLA. Together with advisers from "the twelve territorial divisions into which the state was divided for the purposes of the survey,"⁴ Olmsted and his staff worked during 1927 and 1928. The result, entitled *Report of State Park Survey of California*, was signed by Olmsted on December 29, 1928, and published by the state early the next year. By consensus it is still regarded, both technically and historically, as one of the most valuable of all known documents on state parks.

In his oft-quoted report Olmsted, referring to "the values arising directly and indirectly from the enjoyment of scenery and from related pleasures of non-urban outdoor life," lists in his usual minute manner "the variety and extent of the means by which these values are sought." He continues:

The kinds of values sought by such means have always been part of the joy of living for many people, but in our time, in America, there has been an enormous increase in the proportion of people who have time left for the pursuit of such values after earning the bare necessities of existence.

These values, together with others which directly make life worth living, as distinguished from things which are valued only because they can be exchanged for something one really wants, are the final things which economic prosperity enables people to buy. In California, today, people are using their economic wealth in the ways above indicated to buy values of this particular kind enormously—incredibly to anyone of a former age or another country. And they will probably seek to buy this kind of values more and more.

4. F. L. Olmsted, *Report of State Park Survey of California* (Sacramento, 1929), p. 9.

How far such values *can* be bought, at any price, by succeeding generations in California will depend largely on the degree to which the physical conditions which make them possible are permanently conserved or are destroyed by the first comers through their wasteful methods of exploiting them.

The enormous development in California of the use of these scenic and recreational values of the out-of-doors has resulted . . . in part from the lavish abundance of naturally favorable conditions of landscape and climate.

But there are signs on every hand that because of this very abundance (and of the increasing rate at which the favorable conditions are being put to use), careless, hasty, shortsightedly selfish methods of exploiting the natural assets of scenic value are rapidly killing the geese that lay the golden eggs.⁵

The California State Park Survey, as the 1929 report is commonly called, contains Olmsted's general specifications for state parks:

The chief criteria for determining which of them should be included in an "ultimate, comprehensive state park system" . . . appear to be these:

1. They should be sufficiently distinctive and notable to interest people from comparatively distant parts of the state to visit and use them . . . Also they should, in general, be situated beyond the limits of urban and suburban communities which have sufficient population and wealth to assume the obligation of providing parks that would be mainly serviceable for the daily use of their own citizens . . .
2. They should be characterized by scenic and recreational resources of kinds which are unlikely to be reasonably well conserved and made available for enjoyment under private ownership . . .
3. They should be as nearly as possible just sufficient in number and extent and character to meet the prospective demands of the people for the kinds of enjoyment which they can provide, and which cannot or will not be supplied by such other means as local parks, national parks and forests, and the use of scenic highways . . .
4. They should be geographically distributed with a view to securing a wide and representative variety of types for the state as a whole, and at the same time making a reasonable assortment of them equitably accessible to the people in each part of the state (pp. 49-51).

Olmsted received recommendations for new state parks from the regional advisers and many other sources. A total of 330 proposals were studied, of which only 125 seemed "projects for favorable discussion in this report" (57).

5. *Ibid.*, pp. 15-17.



354. Richardson Grove State Park, a unit in California's superb system of state parks and beaches.

But, since even these could not possibly be acquired within the limits of the bond issue just popularly approved, Olmsted simmered the list down to a final total of 79, which were then listed and discussed briefly. It is largely on the basis of this list that California's present excellent system of parks and beaches has been built (Fig. 354).

Thus in 1929, sixty-five years after establishment of the first example, the state park movement had at last achieved recognizable momentum. In the course of these years, the role of state parks as vehicles for social service had come to be far more widely understood and accepted. They had become more varied in character as the importance of intensive recreation asserted itself. As they grew more complex, with vastly larger use-populations, the parks confronted landscape architects with ever more demanding problems of design. Also in 1929, of course, came the breakdown of the economy, with its consequent throttling effect on state expenditures. For the next four years the state park movement was, understandably, at almost a standstill as the national catastrophe deepened. Then came the 1932 election of Franklin Roosevelt and, in March 1933, the founding of the Civilian Conservation Corps, credited with having advanced the state park movement by at least a half-century.